

ARTS & ENTERTAINMENT

THE MUSIC VS. THE MAN

Ahead of two Soldier Field concerts next month, how does his hometown of Chicago feel about Kanye West now?

NUCCIO DINUZZO/  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE 2016



LIFE & TRAVEL

Rugged trails and starry skies

Tucson, Arizona, is a city for people who love hiking, biking and other outdoor activities.

GREAT WASTE IN THE GREAT LAKES



University of Toronto biologist Chelsea Rochman, center, and Meredith Omer, left, collect northern pearl dace to be measured for research at the Experimental Lakes Area, in western Ontario on Oct. 1, 2025. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Scientists push leaders to act on microplastics pollution

The tiny particles foul every corner of the Great Lakes, a source of drinking water for 40M people

**By Michael Hawthorne**  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Deep in the boreal forest of western Ontario, scientists do the unthinkable: They dump pollution into remote, self-contained lakes to see what happens.

Canadian researchers curtained off two halves of a lake during the late 1960s and doused each with different fertilizers. Their findings prompted bans on phosphorus-laden detergents that were supercharging algae blooms choking the Great Lakes.

They later documented

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how brain-damaging mercury spewed by coal-fired power plants contaminates fish, showed how gases emitted when burning fossil fuels creates acid rain, and demonstrated how thick Canadian crude oil called bitumen spreads after spills.

One of the latest experiments is unfolding amid the jack pine and spruce trees ringing Lake 378.

A newer team of scientists, led

by University of Toronto biologist Chelsea Rochman, churned a gallon of bright, color-coded microplastics into the water during each of the past three years — an amount intended to mimic bits of pollution in urban storm runoff.

Now the researchers are tracking the different types of plastic, some of which sank to the bottom of the 62-acre lake and others that eventually blew or washed ashore.

Graduate students on Rochman's team are dissecting fish and finding that manmade bits ingested by some of their catch

passed from stomachs into filets.

The team is analyzing microplastics painstakingly collected from plants, rocks, water samples and sticky traps erected along the shoreline.

All of this long-running research at the Experimental Lakes Area, or ELA, is geared toward persuading leaders in the United States and Canada to get off the sidelines and combat a growing, unchecked threat to the Great Lakes, the source of drinking water for 40 million people in

See POLLUTION on Page A10

Data centers near O'Hare get \$100M in tax breaks

Leaders tout benefits as suburban homeowners worry about financial gap

By Alex Nitkin and A.D. Quig  
This story is a collaboration between the Illinois Answers Project and the Chicago Tribune.

More than a dozen data centers near O'Hare International Airport are receiving tens of millions of dollars in local property tax breaks this year, shifting the financial burden onto suburban homeowners even as local leaders tout the benefits of the explosive industry amid growing public backlash.

The impact lands hardest on homeowners in suburbs where the tax base leans on a handful of big businesses. In northwest suburban Northlake, the average homeowner would save more than \$2,000 on their annual tax bill — a difference of almost 30% — if local data centers did not receive valuation reductions and incentives, according to the analysis.

At least 18 northwest suburban data centers won multimillion-dollar breaks in their taxable value from Cook County officials — in one case landing on a valuation far below what the business originally paid to buy its site.

Of those 18, 11 already had special tax incentives approved by local leaders that dramatically reduced the properties' tax burdens over a dozen years, even before the latest board reductions. Twelve of them have a separate special state tax break that saves owners millions on sales and use taxes.

Combined, the assessment reductions and incentives knocked nearly \$2 billion off the taxable property value of data centers across just three suburbs — Elk Grove Village, Northlake and Franklin Park — according to an analysis by the Illinois Answers Project and the Chicago Tribune. That trans-

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INSIDE



ANDY LYONS/GETTY

Preseason tuneup

Caleb Williams and the Bears fell 27-9 to the Bengals in Saturday's preseason matchup. **Sports and chicagotribune.com/sports**

Rift deepens

Historic allies U.S. and Canada fell deeper into a trade war marked by new tariffs Saturday. **Nation & World, Page B5**

Once seen as improbable, 'miracle child' starts high school

Matthew Erickson was born with a rare and aggressive brain tumor

By Angie Leventis Lourgos  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

At the first glimpse of his newly printed high school ID card, freshman Matthew Erickson jumped up and down with excitement, waving the little piece of plastic triumphantly in the air.

"Wow! I got it," he shouted in the halls of Huntley High School earlier this month during a materials pickup event prior to the first day of class. "I love it."

The start of high school seemed an improbable milestone for Matthew almost 15 years

ago, when he was born with an extremely rare and often fatal form of brain cancer.

A prenatal ultrasound just a few weeks before his birth had revealed the first sign of trouble: An excess of cerebral fluid had built up on the unborn baby's brain.

After delivery, the roughly 6-pound newborn seemed strong and healthy, scoring high on the standardized infant assessment done after birth. Yet when surgeons drained the fluid, they discovered a large malignant tumor called a high-grade glioma that had developed in the womb, engulfing most of the right hemisphere of his brain.

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Matthew Erickson, 15, hugs his mom, Sue Erickson, with excitement as his school bus pulls up to take him for his first day of freshman year at Huntley High School on Wednesday. STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE

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WEATHER FORECAST

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MON.

H: 79  
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